AND THE LOOMS FALL SILENT

FROM PASHMINA SHAWLS TO CARPETS, KASHMIRI HANDICRAFTS ARE A GLOBAL BRAND. BUT A GLUT OF CHEAPER PRODUCTS AND LOW WAGES ARE DRIVING MANY SKILLED ARTISANS TO ABANDON THEIR PROFESSION

By MOAZUM MOHAMMAD IN SRINAGAR



FORSAKING HIS TRADE Gulzar Ahmad Zargar, who quit carpet weaving as the wages were too low

HALF A CENTURY BEFORE THOMAS Moore's Oriental romance, *Lalla Rookh* (1817), extolled the beauty of Kashmir as a paradise on earth to the West, its handicraft, especially textiles and shawls, had conquered European capitals. Everyone was bewitched by Pashmina and Shahtoosh shawls—Napoleon gave them to empress Josephine and Queen Victoria was a lifelong devotee. Light and soft, warm and woven in exquisite patterns and designs, Kashmiri shawls became synonymous with the luxury and comfort of the finest wool: 'Cashmere'. Shawls were the premium articles from Kashmir, but intricately carved walnut wood, willow wicker craft and carpets were also prized.

Spread along the banks of the Jhelum, Srinagar has long been home to Kashmir's top artisans who operated out of *karkhanas* (workshops) in residential houses along the narrow lanes of the old city. Unfortunately, descendants of those artisans who left an indelible mark on world fashion are now being forced to give up their traditional craft and shift to ordinary jobs, for all they have to show for generations of devoted work is penury.

In Eidgah Narwara in Srinagar, artisans from some 400 *karkhanas* once trained and worked in each segment of Kashmiri craft, ranging from weaving to designing of shawls. From a *naqqash* (designer) to an artisan, the area was a hive of talent. Till a few decades back, residents would have their children follow in their ancestors' footsteps, as wages were decent. Ahtisham